

# Why the Present Moment is So Important (Geneva May 2006)

Bhante Bodhidhamma · International Talks · 52:35

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*Namo tassa bhagavato arahato samma sambuddhassa*

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Homage to the Buddha, the noble one, the awakened one, who realised enlightenment by himself.

I would now like to go into the main points of our practice and also explain the hindrances. Why is it so important to be present, to be in the present moment? Whatever the methods of practice - whether Zen, Theravada - the important thing is to be in the present moment. So you can compare your response with mine.

When we speak of the present moment, it means that we see it as it is, and not that we see what it should be. What stops us from seeing the present moment as it is? Tell me yourself - this isn't a test.

Every time we are in the present moment, we bring the past with us into the present moment. Think about it. When you go to a restaurant and order a pizza, before eating the pizza you know very well how the pizza will be. You've had hundreds of pizzas. You've had hundreds of pizzas, many pizzas. And you've watched television programmes about how to make pizza. You've already discussed pizza with your friends. When you order a pizza, you know what an ideal pizza is. When you know that the pizza doesn't correspond to your ideal of pizza, it's not a pizza.

Every time you have an experience, we define it in relation to past experience, to what we have experienced in the past. Suppose someone invites you to their house to have pizza. I don't know how they sell pizzas here, but let's say there are pizzas that are served that have been refrigerated, that have been frozen. You can put them in the microwave. If your friend invites you and serves you this kind of pizza, then you think it's really not a pizza. But you eat it anyway, let's say, out of respect for your friend, so as not to insult your friend.

Let's suppose you've never had a pizza in your life and you eat this one as your first pizza. Then you could tell your friend that you had a wonderful meal - a somewhat dubious slice of pizza with a little tomato on it. So you can see, every moment we spend, every moment we experience, we bring all our past to that moment.

Even when you entered this room, you should have had an opinion that arose - yes, an opinion, a preconceived opinion: good, not good, pleasant, unpleasant. So the mind is always judging, always judging

in relation to past experience. And the mind never experiences the present moment in all its freshness. In this way, we continue our delusion about life. Through this process, we continue our illusion about what life is.

Every morning we wake up and say, "Here I am." In the evening, when we go to bed, we say goodbye. We disappear. Where are we when we sleep? Who are you when you sleep? Can you be a celebrity when you sleep? And when the alarm rings, there you are. You reappear. Are you the same person who went to bed the evening before? It seems to be the case. We don't feel different from what we were when we went to bed. So essentially, when I wake up, I say to myself, "Hey, here I am again."

So this "me" - what does it refer to? The body. Is it the same body I had when I was two years old? Are they the same emotions I had when I was two or three years old? Are they the same thoughts I had when I was two or three years old? When I was ten years old, twenty years old, forty years old? So what does "me" mean?

So our practice, our meditation, is to bring us into the present moment without any history from the past. And what does this mean, our history, our past? Thoughts. These are thoughts. Concepts. Our concepts and our thoughts bring our past experiences. Every time I say "pizza," I imagine a hundred kinds of pizzas. Every time I say "me," what do I bring, what do I think? All my education, all the concept I have of myself, all the judgments I have about myself.

Every time, I carry this burden and I cling to this burden. All this burden, all this baggage comes down to a single word: me. Me. In meditation, we try to get rid of all this story of all this "me."

How do we do this? We do it mainly by... This is why in this tradition taught by the Venerable Mahāsi, we use only one word for each thing we do. When we contemplate the breath, it's only rising, falling, or for walking, lifting and lowering. By using a single word, naturally we don't think about other things, but my attention is not on the word, it's not on the thought - it's on the sensation.

So there is an intelligence in us. There is an intelligence in us that doesn't think. In our society, in our education, we think that intelligence is thought. We think that intelligence is imagery, philosophy, the arts - and that's intelligence. But the arts, philosophy, technology - all of that is only the expression of intelligence, but it's not intelligence itself. Just as a picture, a beautiful picture is an expression of an emotional experience, but it is not the emotional experience itself.

We must rediscover our original intelligence. The period when we have this original intelligence is when we were small. When you see children looking at something, you can see that their eyes are fixed on the object they're looking at. Absolute stillness. When the jaw is relaxed in meditation and the tongue is relaxed, it means that you can't think. You can experiment with this when you walk in a park. When you relax your jaw and your tongue, your thinking diminishes.

When a child looks at something with complete receptivity, there is no thought in their mind. They don't

come from a position, from an opinion, because the child has no opinion. When they stop to look and ask what it is, the parents say it's a... what's it called? A ladybird. Ladybird. So now they've seen the ladybird, they'll be able to recognise another ladybird. So every time they see a new ladybird, the child won't see this ladybird here but will bring the ladybird from the past.

When we want to rediscover the new ladybird, we should contemplate it, contemplate it, contemplate it, until the moment when there is no more thought. And it's at that moment that we can rediscover the ladybird. It's like when you smell a perfume like that of a rose. You must continue to smell it until the moment when the concept "rose" disappears. It's only when the word...

So you can understand, if we want to see ourselves as we are, we must go beyond any concept of who we are. If you discover what you really are, you must go beyond all concepts of the self. The strength of meditation is to bring us into the present moment without any concept.

So the first thing we must do is stop thinking about something. If we use a single word like "thinking," dreaming, pain, pleasure, sadness, at that moment we really stop thinking. At that moment, we stop thinking about something. And by using a simple word to keep the thinking mind at ease, we can put our attention on sensations and feelings.

At that moment, if we can keep the mind on one word and keep the mind still, at that moment we can feel sensations. Feelings are immediate. You can no longer have a sensation from yesterday. You can no longer feel yesterday's sensations. You can't even feel the emotions from the last moments. So if we can feel a sensation now, if we can feel an emotional state now, we know we are in the present moment.

Every time the mind wanders and dreams or fantasises, at that moment we are completely outside the present moment. When the mind wants to wander, we can't prevent it. When we want to stop the mind... So you must treat the mind as you would a little dog. When we train it to sit and when we ask it to come back, come back, we must be gentle but firm with the mind.

And when we are sitting and the mind wanders, we must note, for example, dreaming, dreaming, then bring it back to the breath. When we wake up and feel anxious, we don't return to the breath or to the body, but we must note the sensation - anxious, worry, worry.

The emotion or the fantasy will indicate to us what sensation is disturbing us. Let's say we are excited and feel angry - we must note them, but we must return to the sensation. We must understand very clearly that emotion cannot develop without being a consequence of the mind and imagination using thoughts and images to develop.

If we experience an emotion as a sensation in the body, we try to receive it and we let it disappear. The emotion will dissolve by itself. You must remember that these are only energies. They need your involvement to develop. They come automatically when you start thinking.

So for example, I'm sure that someone said something to you that displeased you this morning, and you dismissed it as stupidity. But when you have a glass of coffee or tea... And during lunch, you give the person a punch. When evening comes, you'll need an aspirin. That person only insulted you once. But you make sure that, in the end, they insult you a thousand times - through the brain, through thought, through thought. And so these emotions develop.

When we really understand this, we will make an effort, not only in meditation, but in all our lives. When we understand this, not only in meditation sessions, but in daily life, we must stop all these fantasies. Meditation is only to practise how to live daily life.

So whatever the mind thinks, no matter what it is, pleasant or not, no matter, you note it and you return to the mind, you return to the sensation, to the emotion, in the body, as a felt sense. When an emotion comes, whether pleasant or unpleasant... Any thought, pleasant or unpleasant, you return to the sensation in the body, as a sensation as you experience it in your body. This intelligence that we're discussing must be re-embodied, integrated back into the body.

OK, so this is our practice - walking, sitting, even outside, when you eat on Monday, stay with the body, with the sensations of eating. So I'll explain this when we resume after lunch. When we walk, when we sit, or when we go outside and when we eat, we must always return to the sensation in the body. I'll explain the eating after. So that's the side of thinking.

The other side is falling asleep - falling asleep from lethargy and dullness in the head. There is a difference between being tired and being lethargic. The distinction is a bit difficult, but when you have slept well the previous night, you can make the distinction that when you are tired, it doesn't come from fatigue, but it's torpor or lethargy. Torpor is in the mind - it's a bit like soup. At that moment, the body doesn't feel comfortable. Sometimes one thing, sometimes both things.

Now, where is it found? How do we develop these unfavourable states? We will note that this is true for all pleasure. Isn't it true that going to bed is pleasant? One of the beautiful things about sleep is that there is no suffering. It's not *Nibbāna*, but there is no suffering. It's like a refuge too. Just as you take refuge in the Buddha, you take refuge in your bed. When we are angry or depressed, a sign lights up that says "Go to bed." Let's go to bed.

Now, so sleep is very pleasant. We wake up feeling - usually we wake up feeling fresh. But it's also a refuge from danger. So we build within us a condition of falling asleep when certain conditions are there. So here we are, in meditation, watching the mind, nothing is happening - it's very boring, we fall asleep.

In our society now, it's about creating excitations. All the adverts are telling us to do something, buy something, be happier. If you go to a country where people are still based in an agricultural life, when they still live in the easy flow of nature. Nothing is very exciting that we find in nature. Normally in nature it's only either rain, or sun, or clouds, or rain again. So there is nothing exciting to wait for.

If nothing exciting happens, the mind stays awake. The modern mind is always pushed to go towards excitations, and when there is no excitation, the modern mind falls asleep. This is one of the reasons - I don't know the only one - that we see in sleep the place to find happiness. Unfortunately, we cannot be awake when we sleep - it's not possible, what a pity.

And the reason is that the process of liberation is the process of investigation to see things as they are. One of the reasons why the process of liberation is to find, is in the process of investigating, analysing things as they are. And this analysis and investigation can only be done in the absence of thought. We must discover things as they are before thinking how they are.

What does it mean when we are told that we must see... We must be liberated from suffering. The Buddha said that we should observe three things so that our life is completely transformed. And I ask for time just to mention them in passing.

The first thing is that all things appear and disappear radically. Each thing appears and disappears. The next thing that appears is not really similar to the first. They are two different things. It's like the leaves on a tree. Each year, they are not the same. They seem to be the same, but they are not the same. They are different. It's like when you observe your breath - the present breath is different from the one that passed, that preceded.

The second thing that the Buddha asks us to see is how we have created what we call a dualistic world. How we like something and how we hate another thing. That's not the problem. The problem is that when we like something, we grasp it, we attach to it. And when we don't like something, we try to get rid of it. And if it's too big, we attack it. If it's too dangerous, we try to escape.

Let's say the three things that explain that this state is illusion - acquisition, which is grasping, and the other is fear. Yes. Acquisition. Acquisition, aversion. That's acquisition, that's grasping, rejection, and the other is fear. Fear. That's it.

And the third thing that the Buddha says we must see very clearly is the idea we have of ourselves, the self-concept. The definition of a self is that we control, that we can control this self. At that moment, we must investigate this cycle, this body, to what extent we can control it. If we cannot control this body, then it means it cannot be me.

These three investigations will undermine our illusion of a self. When this illusion is broken, the Buddha does not say that we will be annihilated or that we will disappear. He says there is an experience we will have, a state that will no longer suffer or feel satisfaction. And this state is *nibbāna*.

We can approach *nibbāna* in our meditation by observing in a simple and pure way. When we can observe the body with its sensations there, and when we can observe the sensations there that are not us, and when you meditate well, you will be able to observe a thought that appears and disappears before you. You will access an observation post. And this position is very close to *Nibbāna*, right next to it, close,

close. This is what we are trying to do—approach *Nibbāna*.

You don't need to go anywhere. Now that I have given you the foundations, you can do walking meditation. You just need to find a space where you could take five steps and go back and forth and return. A space where you could take five steps. You can find a position in this hall, ten steps, ten steps.

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